

HORS D'OEUVRES **DILIP BOBB**

The Cost of Happiness



Despite the fact that we today have six times the real purchasing power of our parents, I see very few people around me who are genuinely happy. The strain has only increased with the cost of living—and driving—going through the penthouse. We work longer hours than ever before and have higher levels of stress than any other generation in history. The concept of true happiness in today's self-centred world is pretty much a Utopian dream.

Here's one solution: go out and buy it! But before you hare off to the nearest mall waving your platinum card, listen to this. A team of researchers have calculated the best ways to achieve happiness and what it would cost. The researchers collated information from questioning 10,000 people in Europe to calculate what effect finances and lifestyle have on emotions. After being questioned on things that brought them happiness, the respondents were placed on a Life Satisfaction Scale of one (almost suicidal) to seven (euphoric). They then calculated how far changes in lifestyle and social relationships would move the average person up the scale and then put a "price" on social and lifestyle factors. Surprisingly, the money people earned made a relatively minor contribution to their level of personal happiness.

In general, the researchers found that materialistic values are counter-productive: over time they heighten insecurity, a primary causes of unhappiness. The research shows that lifestyle issues conducive to happiness include fit and healthy bodies (excellent health was worth the equivalent of Rs 2.4 crore a year), meeting up with friends frequently (Rs 50.5 lakh), living with someone (Rs 65 lakh), marriage (Rs 42 lakh), and chatting regularly with neighbours (Rs 32 lakh). In contrast, marital break-ups—widowed, separated, divorced—and those with poor health and very few friends faced the equivalent of a Rs 2 crore a year drop in earnings.

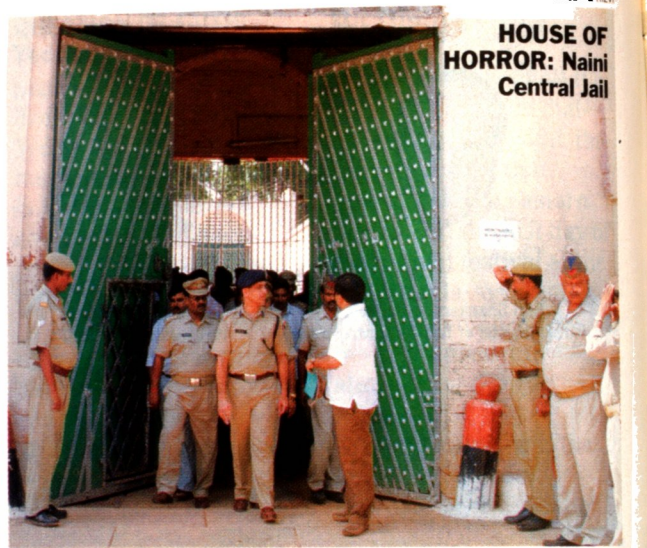
Basically, the research underscores the importance of social relationships and that income and exercise of power have very little to do with overall contentment with life. Ironically, it's something that was known way back in AD 785 when Abd Er-Rahman, then emir of Córdoba, wrote these lines: "I have now reigned 50 years... beloved by my subjects, dreaded by my enemies, and respected by my allies. Riches and honours, power and pleasure, have waited on my call, nor does any earthly blessing appear to have been wanting to my felicity. In this situation, I have diligently numbered the days of pure and genuine happiness which have fallen to my lot. They amount to fourteen."



SAURABH SINGH

SHEERAZ KHAN

HOUSE OF HORROR: Naini Central Jail



Euthanasia From Hell

DELHI Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati may have taken it upon herself to rid her state of decay, but Naini Central Jail in Allahabad is going through a rot within. Ninety-seven prisoners lodged here for over 14 years have petitioned President Pratibha Patil seeking early release or mercy killing. Inmates resent that politically-connected prisoners have been released before their sentence was over.

"We thought that if we behaved well, we would get freedom after 14 years but a longer period has elapsed and we have given up hope. It is now the end of the road for us and even our families have given up hope of our release. In such a situation, we feel there is no purpose to our lives and we request you to give us permission to end our lives," the letter says. "If there's no response, we will plan a mass suicide. There is no point in living aimlessly in jail," says a convict.

The plea for euthanasia is not without reason. In the past five months, 17

inmates have died in this high-security facility for want of medical attention. Nearly 240 inmates are suffering from tuberculosis, scabies and water-borne diseases. Jail authorities deny prisoners access to hospitals and basic medical facilities, citing an acute staff crunch. It is not surprising that the 97 convicts see little hope of being released.

Incidentally, it was in Naini Central that former prime minister Indira Gandhi was jailed by the British in 1942 on charges of subversion. More recent inmates have been ousted SP MP Ateeq Ahmad and his brother and former SP MLA Mohammad Khalid Azeem who were lodged here in connection with the murder of BSP MLA Raju Pal. Other prisoners include Jaish-e-Mohammad and Lashkar militants who have clashed inside the prison in the recent past.

Meanwhile, for the 97 inmates of Naini Central, euthanasia seems preferable to living in this "hell".

by **Rahul Tewari**